BEYOND THE MYTH

The Definitive Guide to Modern Tantra

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FREE SAMPLE: Foreword & Chapter 1

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Foreword

I am nobody.

I have no titles. No lineage authorizing me. No certificate to make me look legitimate.

I grew up in the West Village of New York City. There was a lot of crazy city going on at that time. My mother had a tantric experience that changed her life. Before it, she complained a lot. After it, she pointed at me. You need to study with him. She meant a tantra teacher who had been raised in the jungles of South America. He was the kind of city crazy you only meet a few times in a life.

That's the guy I ended up studying with. Sexual energy and tantra started there.

What follows is what one body has learned in decades of practice — with teachers I followed and teachers I left, with lovers, with books, with vipassana retreats and yoga retreats, and decades of work toward alleviating trauma in the body. Some of what I learned was useful. Most of it was not. Much of it was wrong. I have changed my mind. About many things, many times. Until, one day, I touched a grounded truth. People have called what I experienced enlightenment.

I call it clarity.

No myth, no story, no cult, no group, no belief system, no religion can contain infinitely expanding life. All of them fail, at some point. That is reality. That is the clarity.

However, some things persist.

This book hands you what has persisted. Hard-won. Tried on the body. Willingness to be wrong. Willingness to let everything go.

Like the sunrise and the sunset. Principles around Tantra, the body, and sex outlast every myth, religion, belief system, or group that has ever tried to contain them.

The only requirement from you is willingness to be open. To try things on.

I live in the constant unknown. That is where my teachings flow from.

To take them in, you will need to be open to being open.

Come in.

Chapter 1 — The Animal That You Are

You are an animal.

A primate. A warm, breathing, upright primate that walked the African grass for a couple million years before it ever sat at a desk. Fire came late. Language, farming, cities — late. The screen, the stillness you're sitting in right now — that came in the last blink of an eye.

The animal is what you are. Everything else is what we learned to lay on top.

I've spent decades chasing the thing people chase when they say enlightenment, freedom, peace — and I started where almost everyone starts: trying to get out of the body. Vipassana. Yoga. Twelve teachers across three continents. Breathwork until I saw colors, saw visions. Fasting. Eleven days without a word. The works. None of it landed the way the books promised.

What woke me up was the opposite. Stop trying to leave. Sit down inside the thing. Look around. Feel what's actually moving in here.

And what's in here is an animal. A fantastic, magical animal — far more than the culture ever let you believe. The culture told you the animal was the problem. The thing to manage, to repent, the thing dragging you toward hell. Your animal is not the problem. Your animal is the way through.

So this is a walk through the equipment. The real equipment. The skin. The nerves. The gut. The breath. The sex organs, and the brain those organs are wired straight into. Sacred equipment — though nobody ever handed you the manual. Once you feel what's actually under the hood, the rest of this book opens on its own. Without it, even the most beautiful practice becomes one more instruction you follow in the dark, not knowing why your own hands are moving.

What I know about the animal, and the energies alive inside it, as plainly as I know how.

Evolution as the operating manual

The body you're sitting in was built by evolution. Not designed. Not gifted. Selected.

The ancestors who didn't reproduce died without a line of progeny. The ones who fucked — a lot, with many, far past whoever they called a partner — those are the ones you came down from. Every one of them, all the way back. You are the cumulative settlement of millions of years of bodies that wanted each other badly enough to make more bodies.

The shapes. The appetites. The fears. The way your heart speeds when you see something you want, and slows when you hold someone you love. All of it laid down across deep time by one quiet, relentless force: which bodies made more bodies.

That sentence bothers some people. So I'm just an animal driven by reproduction? No. I'm saying the equipment was shaped by sex — by people who needed to fuck other people. What you do with the equipment now is yours. But running it well without knowing what it was built for is like using a car for a cereal bowl. Sure, you could. Why would you?

You came from fuck. That's not crude — that's the plain fact of it. Fuck is what made you. And fuck is what built the cities, what drives the armies, what's underneath the wars. The whole churning thing runs on it. And then you get handed the big lie: that this — the very force that made you — is not a good thing. Something to be ashamed of. Sit with why anyone would teach you that. When you make a person's deepest drive into a thing to be ashamed of, you've found the hidden shame button on them. Shame is the lock somebody else holds the key to. Make a human ashamed of her own engine and you don't have to control the human — she'll do it for you. That's the trick. The drive was never the problem. The shame laid over it is the leash.

Your body is an evolutionary product. Everything it does, it does because some version of doing it kept your ancestors alive long enough to make you. The arousal. The desire. The bonding. The disgust. The reach for comfort. Old equipment, doing exactly what it was built to do — in a world that no longer looks anything like the one it was built from.

And that's where the trouble lives. The shame, the worry about whether what you want is normal, the difficulty coming, the confusion about what you're even allowed to feel — almost all of it is ancient equipment running on a recent operating system. The body is millions of years old. The shame around it is a few thousand. Guess which one wins in the long run.

Look at the timeline and it gets impossible to miss. For more than two hundred and fifty thousand years, sex just happened. No shame. No stories layered over it. No guilt, no fear, no permission slip required. People wanted each other and they came together, and that was the whole of it, for two hundred and fifty thousand years. Then the world changed. The stories arrived. The shame got installed — recently, on purpose, by people it served. We've been living inside that installation ever since, mistaking a few-thousand-year-old program for the truth of what we are. It's time to step out of it. Time to enter the age of sexual adulthood — to meet the oldest thing in us as grown people, without the guilt that was handed to us by someone who profited from the handing.

And there's a reason it's the oldest thing, and the reason matters. Without sex there's no life. Not yours, not anyone's, not the whole long chain of bodies that produced you — every one of them came through it. Only the morality and the mythology pretend otherwise; the plain biology never did. Which means sex isn't one topic among many. It's the conduit the entire thing runs through — and you can't transcend the conduit of all life. People spend lifetimes trying to rise above it, and every road they take loops them straight back, because there's no above to get to. A principle everything else rests on isn't a preference you can opt out of. It's gravity. Drop the pen and it falls — not because the pen approves, but because that's the shape of the floor everything stands on. For a human body, sex is that floor. You don't transcend gravity. You learn to stand in it. And the moment you stop fighting it and see it as the plain fact it is — not sacred, not dirty, just the ground — every bit of energy you'd been spending to rise above it comes back to you, free.

We're not going to fight the body in this book. We're going to learn what it is, what it wants, and how to move with it — how to work with the energies already flowing through it. Working with what's already there: that's what tantra was, before the marketing got hold of it.

Why pleasure exists at all

Pleasure is information.

You were probably taught it was a reward for being good, or a danger for being bad. Both wrong. Pleasure is the body telling you: this — whatever is happening right now — is something I was built to want more of.

The food that tastes good tastes good because the ancestors who tasted similarly flavors and craved them, lived longer. The bodies you find beautiful look that way to you because the ancestors who responded to those bodies made more children. The touch that feels good feels good because the species needed that touch to keep its people alive. None of it is a mystery. All of it is old, and true, and yours.

It runs on three lines.

Survival. Sugar tastes good because sweet, ripe calories were rare. Sleep feels good because sleep does the repair that keeps you alive. Warmth feels good because cold is what took the ones who didn't go looking for the fire.

Bonding. Touch from someone you trust releases the same chemistry a nursing baby releases. Sex floods you with bonding chemicals because the species needed people to stay close long enough to raise slowly developing children. The afterglow is real. It was built to be real.

Signaling. Pleasure tells you what your body wants — your particular wiring — separate from what the culture told you to want. And the body's pleasure is older than the culture's instructions. When you light up around a certain person, a certain room, a certain sensation, that's reliable information about what you're calibrated to respond to. The signal is rarely wrong. What's usually wrong is the shame somebody laid on top of it.

Your body gives clear signals all day: what you want, what you do not, who to move toward, who to move away from, what feels alive, what feels dead. Most of us were trained to ignore them. Inappropriate. Not spiritual enough. Not what good people want.

You are allowed to want what your body wants. What you do about it is a separate question, and we'll spend the rest of the book there. But the wanting itself is information, not sin. The body has been quietly telling you the truth this whole time.

And there's a precise reason you stopped listening to it. The installation isn't only out there in the culture — it got wired into you, personally, one nervous system at a time. I feel good in my body got fused to something bad is going to happen — put that down, put that away. Two things that have nothing to do with each other, soldered together until they fire as one. The good feeling rises and the dread rises right behind it, automatic, faster than thought. That's not a flaw in you. Odds are, that's how you were taught. Nearly everyone got smacked down for their sexual energy at some point — a look, a word, a hand pulled away, a door that should've stayed open — and the wiring stuck. The pleasure and the punishment came in together, so now they travel together. That's the inherited block, and naming it precisely is the first step to pulling the two wires apart.

If pleasure is information, then so is everything else — and any of it can be turned.

Anything can be sexualized. Every sensation a body can have — every smell, every taste, every texture, the ones you reach for and the ones you may well have learned to flinch from — every one of them is raw charge, and raw charge can be routed. The disgust the culture handed you is not a wall. It's a strong energy with a lock on it, and a strong energy is exactly the kind you can turn into heat, into interest, into power. The body was never the problem. The sorting laid on top of it — this feeling is allowed, that one is dirty — that was the problem, and the sorting can come undone. Hold that as you read everything that follows: there is nothing the body feels that can't be turned around. That one fact opens the whole field.

The nervous system, in plain language

You have one nervous system, with two settings.

The first is on. Heart faster. Pupils wide. Blood out to the muscles. Breath up high and shallow. The body readying to fight, to run, to lock onto a threat — or, sometimes, to chase something it wants. The textbooks call it sympathetic activation. Call it on.

The second is open. Heart slows. Eyes soften. Blood moves back toward the gut and the genitals. Breath drops low and slow. This is the body digesting, healing, growing, repairing, bonding, getting curious, getting aroused, getting sleepy. The textbooks call it parasympathetic. People call it off — but off is the wrong word, because nearly all the good stuff lives here. Open is the truer name.

Bodies move between on and open all day. Some moments call for one; some for the other. A body that can slide between them is doing well. Trouble starts when it gets stuck.

And most adults are stuck in on. The switch jammed in the active position, the open side never getting its turn. It shows up as anxiety, insomnia, low desire, gut trouble, a short fuse, that nameless sense that something's wrong. A body running a half-marathon all day, every day, against an enemy that isn't there.

Almost every practice in this book has the same quiet aim: bring the body back to open, on purpose, long enough that open starts to feel like home again. Breath does it. Sound does it. Slow movement does it. Touch from someone you trust does it. Sex done well does it. Ten minutes on the floor does it. Same destination, different roads.

The reason so many of us have lost the thread of our own desire, our creativity, our appetite, our sleep, our patience, our plain joy — it's the same reason every time. The animal never gets back to open. It can't rest, can't digest, can't rise. It's standing guard against a threat that isn't coming.

So most of what we do here is simple: we teach the animal the way back to open. And once you can find open on your own, on demand, most of what carried you to a book about tantra in the first place begins to loosen. Not all at once. But sooner than you'd think.

What "the body knows" actually means

You've heard it a thousand times. The body knows. Listen to your body. Your body has the answers.

Said vaguely, it means nothing. Let me give it a body.

You run on at least three real channels.

The vagus nerve. A great nerve dropping from the base of the skull down through the chest and into the gut, carrying word from nearly every organ up to the brain. That gut feeling you get — it's literal. A real signal traveling up the vagus, reporting on the food, the person across from you, the room you walked into. Not magic. Information. When something feels off about a person and you can't say why, the vagus has usually caught what the thinking mind hasn't gotten to yet — a flicker in the face, a smell, a gap between the words and the breath. Reliable often enough that ignoring it costs more than trusting it.

Interoception — the body feeling its own inside. Hunger. Thirst. Arousal. Tension. Warmth. Fatigue. The small pressure that means you've been holding your breath. It's how you know what's happening in there. Most adults have gone faint on this one, and not by accident — they were trained out of it. Don't eat now, you'll spoil dinner. You can't be tired, it's only nine. You're not hungry, you just ate. The override voices get loud, the body's voice goes quiet, and by their thirties a lot of people genuinely can't tell hungry from tired from aroused from bored. Nearly every practice in this book is, underneath, a way of turning that channel back up. You get quiet. You notice what the body's doing. You stop telling it what it should feel, and start asking what it does feel — and you let the answer rise to where you can read it.

Proprioception — the body knowing where it is in space. Where your arm is with your eyes closed. How far the knee is bent. What lets you walk down dark stairs, or find your nose without a mirror. It runs constantly, just under awareness. Sharpen it and a lot improves — movement, balance, healing — and one that doesn't get talked about: pleasure. A body that knows where it is can feel itself touched more precisely. A body gone numb to where it is has usually gone numb to sensation, period. Bring proprioception back and you bring back the capacity to feel.

So the body knows turns out to be true and specific. Three channels — vagus, interoception, proprioception. All three carry real information. All three can be grown. And all three are what tantra has been training all along, even back when the tradition called it by other names.

Closing

You are an animal — created by evolution to want, feel, signal, and respond. Two settings, on and open, and most of us get stuck in the on position. Three channels of knowing — vagus, interoception, proprioception — reporting the truth of what's happening inside you, underneath whatever the mind's been told to think.

The rest of this book is the manual for the equipment.

The next six chapters form a cycle: breath, sound, movement, touch, stillness, receiving, and then back to breath. Each one a road back to open, each one a way to switch the body's knowing back on. You don't have to believe anything. You don't have to take on a worldview. You need a body. You're already holding one.

You'll feel things you haven't felt in a while — and a few you may never have felt clearly before. That's the deal.

Keep going

Read the beginner's guide: tantra-authority.com/what-is-tantra/

Tantra for Men (book, $19.97)

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